“My boss will always find fault with me.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

A critical parent, teacher, or earlier boss can train us to scan every authority figure for disapproval. At work, a brief tone or a correction can feel like proof that we are in trouble. If we have actually worked under harsh managers, we may expect it everywhere.

What Scripture teaches

Paul says, “Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men,” and “Serve with good will, as to the Lord and not to men, because you know that the Lord will reward each one for whatever good he does.” Our final evaluator is not our manager. Proverbs says, “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger.” And “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone.” We take feedback seriously without letting criticism define us. Some bosses are unfair, and then boundaries, documentation, and wise counsel may be needed.

> *“Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men”* (Colossians 3:23).

Also see

> “Serve with good will, as to the Lord and not to men, because you know that the Lord will reward each one for whatever good he does, whether he is slave or free” (Ephesians 6:7–8).

> “A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger” (Proverbs 15:1).

> “If it is possible on your part, live at peace with everyone” (Romans 12:18).

> “For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust” (Psalm 103:14).

Common self-statements

- No matter what I do, they will criticize me.
- Every email from my boss is a warning.
- I am always one mistake from trouble.
- They have it in for me.
- I cannot do anything right.
- I dread every meeting.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming my boss’s negative intent.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating one correction as constant fault-finding.
- Mental filter: Focusing on criticism and missing positive feedback.
- Personalization: Taking neutral comments as personal attacks.

Challenging questions

- What has my boss actually said or done, as opposed to what I assume?
- Have I received any praise or neutral feedback that I discounted?

- Whom did I first expect to find fault with me?
- Is the feedback accurate, and what can I learn from it?
- If the boss really is unfair, what steps are wise?
- Whom do I ultimately work for?

Truth summary

> I can work wholeheartedly for the Lord and receive feedback without being crushed by it. I can distinguish fair critique from my fear. If the treatment really is unfair, I can respond with wisdom, boundaries, and help.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Occupation/Job/Work
- Fear
- Anxiety/Worry
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Wisdom

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "My boss will always find fault with me"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"My boss will always find fault with me." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What has my boss actually said?
- ☐ What positive feedback have I received?
- ☐ Whom do I expect to criticize me?
- ☐ What can I learn?
- ☐ What if it is unfair?
- ☐ Whom do I work for?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I work for the Lord first.
- ☐ Feedback is information, not a verdict.
- ☐ A gentle answer turns away wrath.
- ☐ God knows I am dust and has compassion.
- ☐ I can seek wise counsel.
- ☐ I am not defined by my boss's opinion.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Colossians 3:23
  "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men."
- ☐ Proverbs 15:1
  "A gentle answer turns away wrath, but a harsh word stirs up anger."
- ☐ Psalm 103:14
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Facts at work: Each day, write one factual piece of feedback and one thing that went well.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Colossians 3:23 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I work for the Lord first, so my boss's opinion does not define me.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Collect the facts. Write down actual comments from your boss for two weeks.
- [ ] Ask for clarity. Request a short meeting about expectations.
- [ ] Receive one correction. Respond calmly, "Thank you, I will work on that."
- [ ] Seek counsel. If treatment seems unfair, talk to HR or a wise adviser.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "My boss will always find fault with me": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Facts, not fear
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~My boss will always find fault with me.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I work for You first. Calm my fear of criticism, help me learn from fair feedback, and give me wisdom when treatment is unfair. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“I have to be perfect or I'll lose my job.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Perfectionism at work often starts in childhood, where mistakes were punished or achievement was praised. A real workplace layoff, a harsh review, or a close call can cement it. We work late, double-check everything, and feel nervous after every small error.

What Scripture teaches

The psalmist says, “He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust.” Solomon notes, “There is no righteous man on earth who does good and never sins.” Proverbs says, “Though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up.” God told Paul, “My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.” God does not expect perfection from us at work, and most employers do not either. Excellence is worthwhile; perfection is impossible and exhausting.

> *“For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust”* (Psalm 103:14).

Also see

> “Surely there is no righteous man on earth who does good and never sins” (Ecclesiastes 7:20).

> “For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times” (Proverbs 24:16).

> “But He said to me, ‘My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.’ Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me” (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> “The steps of a man are ordered by the LORD who takes delight in his journey. Though he falls, he will not be overwhelmed, for the LORD is holding his hand” (Psalm 37:23–24).

Common self-statements

- One mistake and I am out.
- I cannot afford any errors.
- Everyone else is flawless.
- I must work twice as hard.
- I will be found out.
- Perfect or nothing.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing that anything short of perfect is failure.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that one error will cost my job.
- Should statements: Insisting that I should never make mistakes.
- Magnification: Treating minor errors as major.

Challenging questions

- What is the actual standard in my workplace, and how do I know?
- Have I seen coworkers make mistakes and keep their jobs?
- What happened the last time I made an error?

- What does perfectionism cost me in time, health, and relationships?
- What would “good and reliable” look like?
- What does God expect of me?

Truth summary

> I do not have to be perfect to keep my job or to be valued. God knows I am dust, and my worth does not depend on flawless work. I can aim for good, honest work and learn from mistakes without fear.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Anxiety/Worry
- Tired
- Pride
- Occupation/Job/Work
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Unemployment

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God’s care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Living Hope — Phil Wickham
Christ’s resurrection and forgiveness provide hope beyond sin and death.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: “If I truly believed God’s truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?”

My Plan for Replacing "I have to be perfect or I'll lose my job"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I have to be perfect or I'll lose my job." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What is the real standard?
- ☐ What happened after my last mistake?
- ☐ What does perfectionism cost me?
- ☐ What is good enough?
- ☐ What does God expect?
- ☐ When can I rest?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God knows I am dust.
- ☐ No one is perfect.
- ☐ I can get up after mistakes.
- ☐ His grace is enough.
- ☐ Good work is enough.
- ☐ I can rest from perfectionism.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Psalm 103:14
  "For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- ☐ Ecclesiastes 7:20
  "Surely there is no righteous man on earth who does good and never sins."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Good enough: Each day, name one task you finished at "good enough" and what happened.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 103:14 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God knows I am dust, so I do not have to be perfect.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Anxiety/Worry" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Define the standard. Ask your manager what "good" looks like.
- ☐ Practice good enough. Do one task without a third check.
- ☐ Track outcomes. Record what actually happens after minor errors.
- ☐ Take real breaks. Leave on time at least twice this week.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I have to be perfect or I'll lose my job": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Good enough
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I have to be perfect or I'll lose my job.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I fear making mistakes. You know I am dust. Free me from perfectionism, and help me work honestly and rest in Your grace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #33 · WORK AND AUTHORITY

"People in authority can't be trusted."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

If a parent, teacher, coach, pastor, or boss abused or betrayed authority, the lesson may stay: authority means danger. We may bristle at supervision, expect to be used, or avoid anyone who has power over us. Real experiences of misuse of power deserve to be taken seriously.

What Scripture teaches

The Bible shows both sides. Paul writes, "Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which is from God." Yet when the council ordered the apostles to stop speaking, Peter and the other apostles replied, "We must obey God rather than men." The psalmist says, "It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man." And "The king's heart is a waterway in the hand of the LORD; He directs it where He pleases." Authority is not always safe, and it is not always unsafe. We can trust God ultimately, and trust people in proportion to their character.

> *"It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in princes"* (Psalm 118:8–9).

Also see

> "The king's heart is a waterway in the hand of the LORD; He directs it where He pleases" (Proverbs 21:1).

> "Everyone must submit himself to the governing authorities, for there is no authority except that which is from God. The authorities that exist have been appointed by God" (Romans 13:1).

> "But Peter and the other apostles replied, 'We must obey God rather than men.'" (Acts 5:29).

> "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight" (Proverbs 3:5–6).

Common self-statements

- Anyone with power will misuse it.
- They will use me and then drop me.
- I cannot rely on bosses or leaders.
- If I submit, I will be hurt.
- I have to protect myself from them.
- Authority is dangerous.

Common logical errors

- Overgeneralizing: Treating every authority as the one who hurt me.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing authorities are either totally safe or totally dangerous.
- Mind reading: Assuming bad motives.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling wary and concluding that all authority is dangerous.

Challenging questions

- Who in authority hurt or betrayed me, and what happened?

- Have any people in authority treated me fairly or kindly?
- How can I tell a trustworthy leader from an unsafe one?
- What does Scripture say about obeying God over people when they conflict?
- How might distrust affect my work and relationships?
- What would healthy, measured trust look like?

Truth summary

> Some people in authority have misused their power, and my caution makes sense. Not all are the same. I can trust God above all, and I can extend trust to people in proportion to their character, with wise boundaries.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Citizenship
- Protection
- Wisdom
- Persecution

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Trouble/Hardship
- Judgmental

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Fear Is a Liar — Zach Williams
Examine fear-driven accusations rather than treating them as reliable truth.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

He Knows — Jeremy Camp
Jesus understands suffering and invites people to bring their burdens to Him.

Great Is Thy Faithfulness — CeCe Winans
This classic hymn recalls God's steady mercy through changing circumstances.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "People in authority can't be trusted"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"People in authority can't be trusted." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who hurt me?
- ☐ Who has been fair?
- ☐ What signs show a safe leader?
- ☐ When do I obey God over people?
- ☐ What does measured trust look like?
- ☐ Who can support me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ My ultimate trust is in the Lord.
- ☐ God directs hearts where He pleases.
- ☐ Not every authority is unsafe.
- ☐ I can obey God over people when they conflict.
- ☐ Trust can be measured.
- ☐ I can protect myself wisely.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 118:8–9**
  "It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in man. It is better to take refuge in the LORD than to trust in princes."
- ☐ **Proverbs 21:1**
  "The king's heart is a waterway in the hand of the LORD; He directs it where He pleases."
- ☐ **Acts 5:29**
  "But Peter and the other apostles replied, 'We must obey God rather than men.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Measured trust: Each week, note one interaction where you gave measured trust and what happened.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 118:8–9 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I take refuge in the Lord first, and I can trust people carefully.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Tell your story. Write what happened with the authority who hurt you.
- [ ] List trustworthy qualities. Write signs of safe leadership, such as honesty, consistency, and humility.
- [ ] Test small. Extend small trust to someone who shows these qualities.
- [ ] Get support. Talk to a counselor if your experiences involved abuse.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "People in authority can't be trusted": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Measured trust
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~People in authority can't be trusted.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, some who held authority over me hurt me. Heal that wound. Teach me to trust You above all and to discern who is safe. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #34 · WORK AND AUTHORITY

"I'll never be respected at work."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Being overlooked, interrupted, or passed over, or being the youngest, newest, or quietest person in a room, can leave us feeling invisible. A history of being dismissed at home or school makes it easier to read workplace slights as permanent verdicts.

What Scripture teaches

Proverbs says, "Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will be stationed in the presence of kings." Paul told Timothy, "Let no one despise your youth, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity." Of Daniel it says, "by his extraordinary spirit, Daniel distinguished himself," and Peter writes, "Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us." Respect often grows from consistent character and competence over time. It is not instant, and we do not control it, but we can build a reputation that speaks.

> *"Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will be stationed in the presence of kings; he will not stand before obscure men"* (Proverbs 22:29).

Also see

> "Let no one despise your youth, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity" (1 Timothy 4:12).

> "Soon, by his extraordinary spirit, Daniel distinguished himself among the administrators and satraps. So the king planned to set him over the whole kingdom" (Daniel 6:3).

> "Conduct yourselves with such honor among the Gentiles that, though they slander you as evildoers, they may see your good deeds and glorify God on the day He visits us" (1 Peter 2:12).

> "In the same way, let your light shine before men, that they may see your good deeds and glorify your Father in heaven" (Matthew 5:16).

Common self-statements

- No one takes me seriously.
- They talk over me.
- I am invisible here.
- I will always be the junior one.
- My ideas do not count.
- They will never see my value.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting permanent disrespect.
- Mental filter: Remembering slights and forgetting respect.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling dismissed and concluding I am.
- Labeling: Calling myself "invisible."

Challenging questions

- Which specific incidents make me feel disrespected, and which people respect me?
- Is my feeling about the whole workplace or about a few people?
- How have I handled the moments when I was overlooked?
- What strengths could I make more visible?
- What does Scripture say about character and reputation?
- What is one small step toward being heard?

Truth summary

> Respect is often built over time through consistent character and good work. I do not control how others treat me, but I can speak up, show competence, and leave my reputation to grow. My worth does not depend on any one coworker's opinion.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Occupation/Job/Work
- Self-Esteem, Low
- Pride
- Humility
- Wisdom

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Unemployment
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Who Am I — Casting Crowns
Being known and cared for by God rests on His love rather than personal importance.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I'll never be respected at work"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'll never be respected at work." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What incidents hurt?
- ☐ Who respects me?
- ☐ What strengths can I show?
- ☐ What will I say in the next meeting?
- ☐ What have I done well?
- ☐ Who can be an ally?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Skilled work stands out.
- ☐ My character can set an example.
- ☐ Daniel distinguished himself over time.
- ☐ My worth comes from God.
- ☐ I can speak up with calm confidence.
- ☐ Respect can grow.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 22:29**
  "Do you see a man skilled in his work? He will be stationed in the presence of kings; he will not stand before obscure men."
- ☐ **1 Timothy 4:12**
  "Let no one despise your youth, but set an example for the believers in speech, in conduct, in love, in faith, in purity."
- ☐ **Matthew 5:16**
  "In the same way, let your light shine before men, that they may see your good deeds and glorify your Father in heaven."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] A moment of respect: Each week, note one moment of respect or one time you spoke up.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 22:29 becomes: "Sarah can write: "Good work and good character speak for themselves over time.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Occupation/Job/Work" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] List the incidents. Write the facts about times you felt disrespected.
- [ ] Prepare to speak. Before meetings, write one point to contribute.
- [ ] Build a track record. Document projects completed well.
- [ ] Find an ally. Build a relationship with someone who values your work.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'll never be respected at work": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A moment of respect
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'll never be respected at work.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I long to be taken seriously. Help me work with integrity, speak with calm confidence, and rest in Your approval whatever others think. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

“If I speak up, I'll be punished.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Speaking up has cost some people dearly: in families where disagreement brought anger, at schools or churches where questions were treated as rebellion, or at workplaces where complaints led to retaliation. We learn to stay quiet, swallow concerns, and agree on the surface.

What Scripture teaches

Paul writes, “God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control.” The Lord told Joshua, “Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go.” Proverbs says, “The righteous are as bold as a lion.” Mordecai asked Esther, “Who knows if perhaps you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?” and the apostles answered, “We cannot stop speaking about what we have seen and heard.” Courage does not mean recklessness. We can speak truthfully and respectfully, choosing wisely when and how, and trusting God with the result.

> *“For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control”* (2 Timothy 1:7).

Also see

> “Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go” (Joshua 1:9).

> “The wicked flee when no one pursues, but the righteous are as bold as a lion” (Proverbs 28:1).

> “For if you remain silent at this time, relief and deliverance for the Jews will arise from another place, but you and your father’s house will perish. And who knows if perhaps you have come to the kingdom for such a time as this?” (Esther 4:14).

> “Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head” (Ephesians 4:15).

Common self-statements

- If I say anything, I will pay for it.
- It is safer to stay quiet.
- They will retaliate.
- No one wants to hear what I think.
- I will lose my job or the relationship.
- Speaking up never works.

Common logical errors

- Fortune telling: Predicting punishment.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining the worst response.
- Overgeneralizing: Treating a past punishment as certain now.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either stay silent or confront.

Challenging questions

- When was I punished for speaking up in the past?
- Is this situation the same, or different?
- What is the actual risk, and what is the cost of staying silent?
- What is the wisest way and time to say it?
- What does God say about fear and courage?
- Who could support me or help me prepare?

Truth summary

> God has given me a spirit of power, love, and self-control. I can speak truthfully and respectfully, choosing the right time and way. If the risk is real, I can prepare, seek counsel, and protect myself.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Fear
- Communication
- Witness
- Protection
- Will of God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Communication
- Anxiety/Worry/Fear

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Same Power — Jeremy Camp
God's power challenges the belief that evil or fear has the final authority.

Battle Belongs — Phil Wickham
Bring fear and uncertainty to God rather than carrying the outcome alone.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I speak up, I'll be punished"

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2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When was I punished for speaking?
- ☐ Is this the same?
- ☐ What is the real risk?
- ☐ What do I want to say?
- ☐ When and how?
- ☐ Who can support me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God has not given me a spirit of fear.
- ☐ The Lord is with me wherever I go.
- ☐ I can speak with respect.
- ☐ I can choose my time and way.
- ☐ Silence has a cost too.
- ☐ I can get support.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ 2 Timothy 1:7
  "For God has not given us a spirit of fear, but of power, love, and self-control."
- ☐ Joshua 1:9
  "Have I not commanded you to be strong and courageous? Do not be afraid; do not be discouraged, for the LORD your God is with you wherever you go."
- ☐ Ephesians 4:15
  "Instead, speaking the truth in love, we will in all things grow up into Christ Himself, who is the head."

A verse I found myself: _____

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  For example, 2 Timothy 1:7 becomes: "Sarah can write: "God has given me power, love, and self-control, so I can speak the truth with respect.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
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6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- ☐ Write what you want to say. Draft it in one or two sentences.
- ☐ Rehearse. Practice with a friend or counselor.
- ☐ Choose the setting. Pick a calm time and place.
- ☐ Document and seek counsel. If the risk is real, keep records and consult HR or an adviser.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

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GOD'S WORD

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Prayer

Father, speaking up has felt dangerous. You have not given me a spirit of fear. Give me wisdom, courage, and gentleness, and protect me as I speak the truth in love. Amen.

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